

The Use of ‘So-Called’ as a Propaganda Device

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Abstract

Propagandists discredit political ideas that rival their own. In China’s state-run media, one common technique is to place the phrase so-called, in English, or 所谓, in Chinese, before the idea to be discredited. In this research note we apply quantitative text analysis methods to over 45,000 Xinhua articles from 2003 to 2022 containing so-called or 所谓 to better understand the ideas the government wishes to discredit for different audiences. We find that perceived challenges to China’s sovereignty consistently draw usage of the term and that a theme of rising importance is political rivalry with the United States. When it comes to differences between internal and external propaganda, we find broad similarities, but differences in how the US is discredited and more emphasis on cooperation for foreign audiences. These findings inform scholarship on comparative authoritarian propaganda and Chinese propaganda specifically.

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Introduction

Propagandists face a dilemma. They want to discredit political ideas that rival their own, but to do so they often must invoke those very ideas for their readers. This entails a risk: perhaps the reader/listener will become curious and wish to learn more. After all, consumers of authoritarian propaganda can sometimes “read between the lines” to glean information or meanings that the propagandists did not intend to disseminate (Weiss and Dafoe 2019, 964).

Including indicators of disapproval in the text is one technique to simultaneously invoke and discredit an idea. In China’s official discourse, one common marker is to place the phrase *so-called* in English or 所谓 in Chinese before the idea to be discredited.¹ Usually, *so-called* is paired with ironic inverted commas around the relevant phrase to underscore the intended disapproval. For example, journalists Mary Hui and Dan Kopf noted the dramatic rise in the use of *so-called* in the official language of Hong Kong as the Chinese Communist Party (CCP or party) consolidated political control over the city in 2019 and 2020. The intent, they write, was for the authorities to “undermine information they find objectionable” (Hui and Kopf 2020; see also Colville 2024).

China is not the only context in which the use of *so-called* or inverted commas can be found. In writing about how language was corrupted by the Nazi regime, Victor Klemperer noted that the ironic inverted comma “questions the truth of that which is quoted, declares that the reported remark is untrue” (Klemperer 1957, 75-76). In the late Soviet Union, Yurchak notes that when translating foreign texts for Soviet audiences “interpreters were advised to use special indexical markers – such as quotations marks, the term ‘so-called,’ and so forth – that would signal to Soviet

readers that the foreign phrases were not used in the proper monosemic sense ‘accepted in our literature’” (Yurchak 2005, 52).²

In *Xinhua*, China’s main state news agency, from 2003 to 2022 we count 22,914 articles containing *so-called* in the agency’s English content and 22,524 articles containing 所谓 in Chinese. In this research note we apply quantitative text analysis techniques to these samples. We have three aims. First, we want to know how, if at all, usage changed over time between 2003 and 2022. Second, we aim to compare the Chinese and English text corpora to understand differences and similarities in what *Xinhua* discredits domestically and internationally. Third, we hope to better understand the specific ideas or entities that the PRC propaganda apparatus wishes to discredit.

More details will be provided below, but temporally we note and further explore a dramatic increase in the use of the term from 2018. Thematically our findings indicate that in both corpora, there are certain core ideas that attract the use of the term *so-called*. These tend to relate to perceived challenges to China’s sovereignty, such as control over Taiwan or Hong Kong. A theme of rising importance in both corpora is systemic political rivalry with the United States. When it comes to differences between internal and external propaganda, we find broad similarities but that Chinese content focuses more on discrediting the US in the context of foreign affairs and less on countering criticisms of China's ethnic minority policies.

These findings are important because they provide a systematic view of the ideas and entities that the PRC discredits for different audiences. Although ours is a brief research note and does not build a theory to explain its findings, we believe our study contributes to key debates. Specifically, this analysis adds to scholarship in comparative authoritarian propaganda by analysing the discrediting of rival ideas and

entities, PRC propaganda specifically by identifying temporal, thematic, and audience targeting patterns, and Chinese politics more generally by showing in new ways ideas that the CCP finds threatening.

Authoritarian Propaganda and De-legitimation

Space constraints of the research note format preclude a comprehensive literature review, but we nonetheless wish to highlight the scholarship we build on and, we hope, advance. Propagandists must contend with ideas, evidence, and/or symbols that unsettle their preferred ideological universe. The most obvious option is to censor them. Authoritarian regimes and the PRC specifically, censor a great deal (for example, see King, Pan, and Roberts 2013; Lorentzen 2014; Roberts 2018). However, censorship brings its own risks insofar as awareness about censorship can motivate people to seek out alternative information (Roberts 2018, 137-145). There are ways to obscure evidence of censorship and censors learn and adapt over time (Guriev and Treisman 2022, 86-113), but inevitably some heterodox ideas sneak through. Sometimes states even encourage the dissemination of criticisms of their own policies if those criticisms are perceived as coming from a disreputable source, thus undermining the criticism itself (Gruffydd-Jones 2022). Censorship aside, some ideas will be reported in propaganda that need to be designated as unacceptable for the audience.

Authoritarian leaders delegitimize ideas because they threaten their own power or interests. Activities or beliefs threatening to authorities' political control become targets for state repression (Davenport 2007). In the Chinese case, we know that the authorities find alternative political ideas threatening because they admit as much. Consider the leaked 2013 inner-party document "Communiqué on the Current State

of the Ideological Sphere”, better known as Document 9, which explicitly framed ideas like human rights, constitutionalism, free media, and questioning the party’s version of history as threats to party rule (ChinaFile 2013). A wide-ranging tightening of the public sphere and crackdown on groups associated with these ideas followed.

The propaganda apparatus is key for delegitimizing ideas threatening to the authorities’ political order. Studies of China’s propaganda system emphasize its importance to CCP rule and its penetration of the public sphere (for example, see Huang 2015; Creemers 2017; Mattingly and Yao 2022). Some argue that much Chinese propaganda is about signalling domination rather than persuading citizens (Huang 2015; Carter & Carter 2023). There is merit to this view, but the ideas themselves matter too, as evidenced by the fact that they often change over time.³ While the study of authoritarian propaganda typically focuses on the ideas that the government wishes to *popularize*, less attention is paid to the ideas that the propaganda apparatus wishes to *discredit* (however, see Chester 2023). Typically the purview of studies on censorship, propagandists still must decide what to do with ideas that they oppose.

Authoritarians use communication strategically to target different audiences at different times (Baturu & Tolstrup 2023). One basic audience distinction among many possible subdivisions is between internal (domestic audiences) and external (foreign audiences). External propaganda has a rich history in the CCP and has long been used strategically to shape foreign perceptions of the party’s goals and practices (Edney 2014; Brady 2015; Tsai 2017). The globalized expansion of the PRC’s external propaganda since around 2008 after pro-Tibet protests and the Beijing Summer Olympics was ambitious and partially borne of the party’s perception that it was unable to steer global conversations, advance its preferred concepts, and marginalize criticism of its policies (Kurlantzick 2023; Gruffydd-Jones 2022, 54-59). Streams of internal and external CCP propaganda intersect (see Edney 2014; Weiss and Dafoe

2019) and unsanctioned messages cross the divide (Lu et al., 2022), but it is still worth exploring differences and similarities between the two if for no other reason than the party retains the distinction. Operating “under the principle that ‘internal and external are different (内外有别)’”, for example, the Central Propaganda Department recommends different messages for internal and external audiences (Perry 2017, 38).

Data, Classification, Validation, and Temporal Trends

To determine how and when *so-called* is used, we searched for all articles containing the term *so-called* and ‘所谓’ within the English and Chinese editions of *Xinhua News Agency*, respectively, over a 20-year period (2003 to 2022). *Xinhua* is chosen because along with the *People’s Daily*, it forms the most authoritative party-state media in China and is geared toward a mass audience (Esarey 2021). *Xinhua* functions as China’s main international newswire, thus allowing comparative analysis of internal and external messaging.⁴

The search yielded 22,914 English-language articles out of a total of 1,895,630 and 22,524 Chinese-language articles out of a total of 1,509,869⁵. The articles were downloaded, imported into R, and cleaned using the *newspapers* (Watanabe 2021), *devtools* (Wickham et al. 2022), *stringi* (Gagolewski 2022), and *lubridate* (Grolemund and Wickham 2011) packages. Further analysis was performed using the *quanteda* R package (Benoit et al. 2018). We adopt a supervised classification approach, which entails training an algorithm on a sub-sample of the data by applying labels and then applying the algorithm to the remaining unlabelled data (see Dai and Luqiu 2022, 264). We use the Naïve Bayes classifier, which is regarded as a well-performing

baseline model upon which more complicated models are based (Grimmer et al. 2022).

To begin, labelled data must be created. Sentences with *so-called* were coded by the researchers into two categories, sarcastic or neutral, based on the context of the sentence. For example, a sarcastic use is: “A Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson on Friday refuted the so-called ‘genocide’ and ‘forced labor’ in Xinjiang that U.S. politicians, in collusion with some anti-China organizations and individuals, have been unscrupulously spreading and hyping up for their ulterior political purpose. [text18145].” A neutral use occurs when *so-called* is used in place of a phrase like “what is dubbed as,” for example: “Indonesia ... is laid on a vulnerable quake-hit zone, the so-called ‘the Pacific ring of Fire’, where two continental plates, stretching from Western hemisphere to Japan, meet that causes frequent seismic and volcanic movements [text827].”

More details about the pre-processing, sampling, and validation steps are available in the Appendix (Section A), but applying a trained classifier on the full corpora, we find that 23.4% of the English-language corpus (5,367 articles) was predicted to be sarcastic, compared to 57.7% for the Chinese-language corpus (13,179 articles). These proportions correspond well to those in the human-coded samples. We further validated by manual inspection of a random sample of 10% of the machine-predicted sample (535 articles for the English-language corpus; 1,238 articles for the Chinese-language corpus), finding that 83.9% and 84.8% of the English and Chinese samples were correctly classified, respectively. In English 69.3% of the mentions of *so-called* were followed by ironic inverted commas and in Chinese 77.5%. *Table A1* in the Appendix presents examples of the sarcastic uses of the term *so-called* that the classifier identified.

Since we are only interested in the sarcastic usage of the term, we focus on those in the analysis, but the fact that neutral usages exist allows us to establish time trends. *Figures 1 and 2* show the distribution of sarcastic articles in proportion to the entire corpus of articles containing the term *so-called*. The figures reveal a dramatic increase in the proportional usage of *so-called* as a marker of disapproval from 2018 in both languages. We are not able to determine with certainty what explains this, but two hypotheses worth exploring are that increased hostility in US-China relations as well as Xi Jinping's efforts to entrench personalistic rule in preparation for a third term may be causing the uptick.

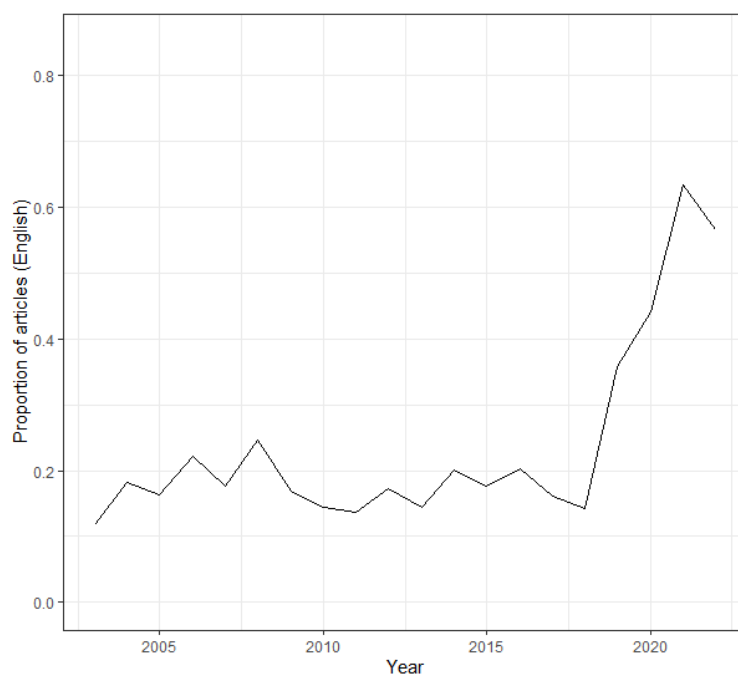


Figure 1. Distribution of sarcastic articles, in proportion to the entire corpus of 22,914 English-language articles containing the term ‘so-called’.

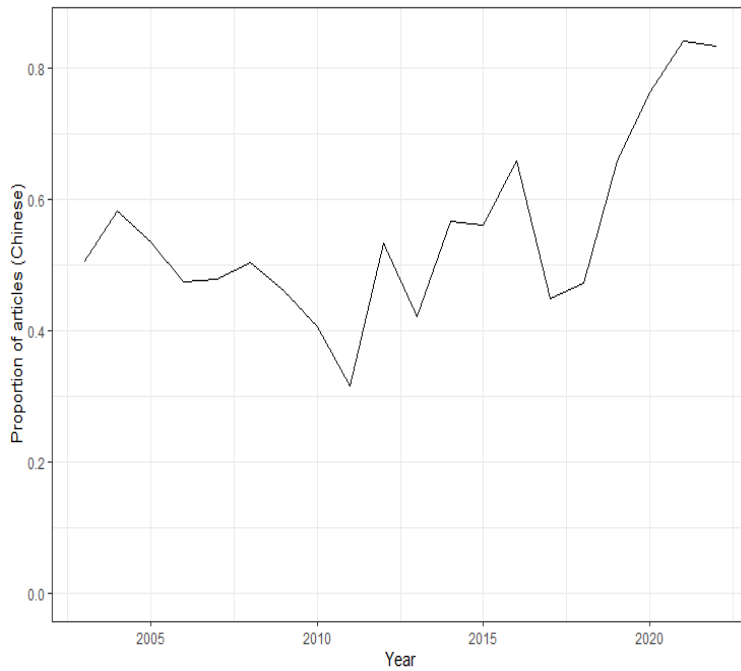


Figure 2. Distribution of sarcastic articles, in proportion to the entire corpus of 22,524 Chinese-language articles containing the term ‘所谓’.

Evaluating Themes & Variation Between Language Editions

With these basics established, we next evaluate if topics and words associated with sarcastic *so-called* markers vary between the *Xinhua* English and Chinese editions. As a first cut, we employ a simple word co-occurrence strategy. *Figures 3 and 4* show textual network analyses. Thicker lines indicate that words co-occur (within a window of 6 features) more often with *so-called*. The top-50 co-occurring terms are shown in Table A4 in the Appendix. Overall, the common terms that frequently occur across both corpora correspond to China’s stated core interests, which include national sovereignty, national security, territorial integrity, and safeguarding its political system (Government of the People’s Republic of China 2011). These tend to relate to issues or actors that have been identified as attracting strong nationalist sentiment, such as the United States, Japan, Tibet, and the South China Sea (Weiss 2014). ‘So-

within the Structural Topic Models (STM) package (Roberts et al. 2019) to identify a baseline number of topics (Lee and Mimno 2014).⁶ Next, we used Keyword-Assisted Topic Models (keyATM) (Eshima et al. 2023). Unlike popular unsupervised models such as the LDA and the STM, keyATM is a semi-supervised approach which “allow(s) researchers to label topics via the specification of keywords prior to model fitting” (Eshima et al. 2023, 2).

Based on the literature, and the results from the STM analysis and the word co-occurrences plots (*Figures 3 and 4*), we identified seven theoretically important topics and generated a list of keywords for each topic.⁷ The seven topics are: territorial disputes, ‘One-China’, foreign affairs, cooperation, rival systems, economy, and ethnic minorities. We then ran the keyATM models based on the seven topics.

Figures 5 and 6 show the distributions of those topics in the two language editions. In both editions, ‘Rival Systems’, ‘Cooperation’, ‘Territorial Disputes’, and ‘One China’ appear within the top five topics.⁸ However, what is clear is that domestically the CCP propaganda apparatus is more preoccupied with delegitimizing the United States and its role in the world. In the Chinese corpus, it appears especially evident that the top two topics, ‘Rival Systems’ and ‘Foreign Affairs’, focus on criticism of US foreign policy. ‘Ethnic Minorities’ appear within the top five topics of the English corpus but is de-emphasized in the Chinese corpus, ranking seventh. Without wishing to over-extrapolate from differences in these samples, the results suggest that for both audiences discrediting ideas associated with rival political systems is important but that the US is further discredited for a domestic audience in the context of foreign affairs. The findings also suggest less of a perceived need to respond to criticisms of ethnic minority policies for a domestic audience.

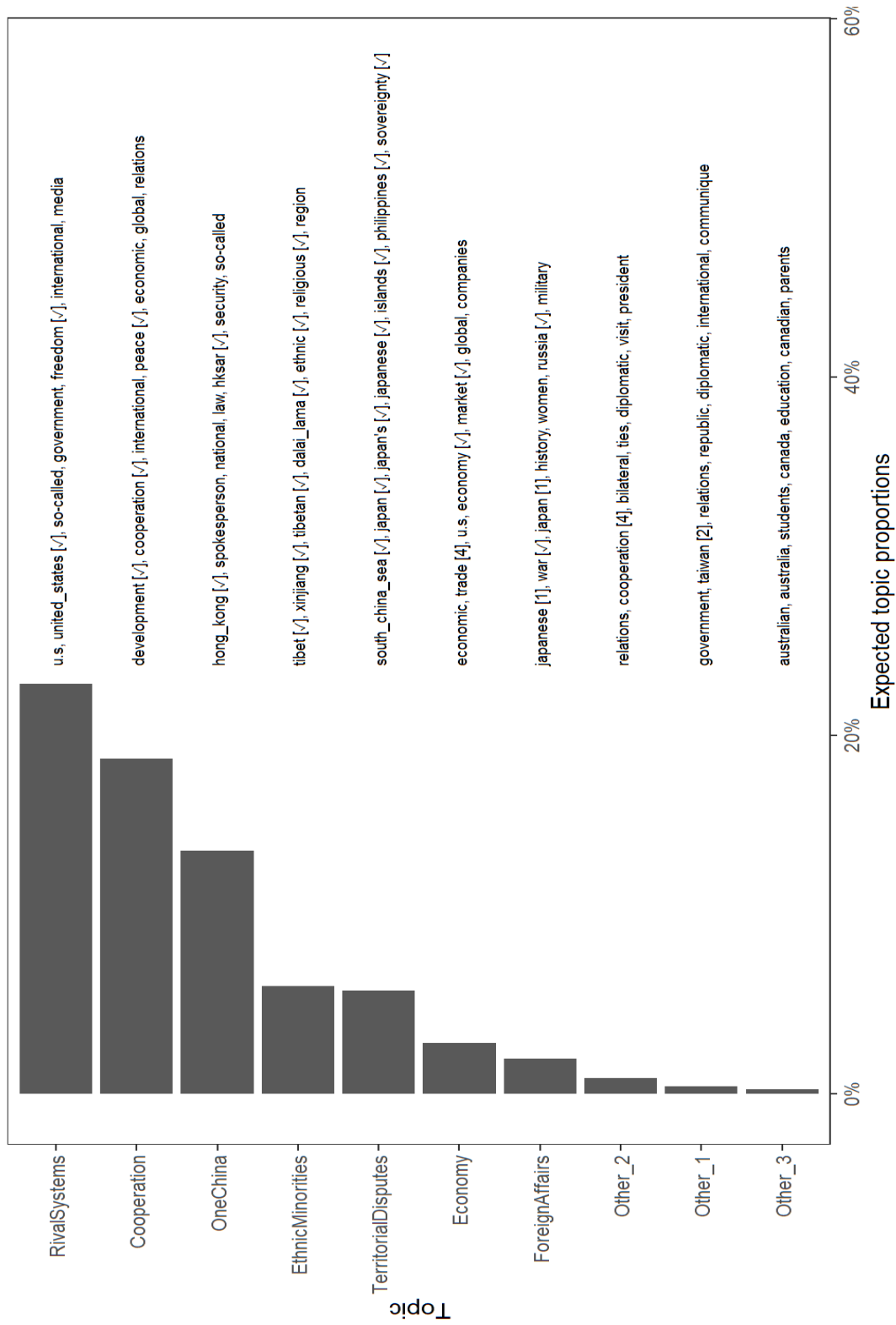


Figure 5. Distribution of top 10 topics and corresponding keywords across English-language articles (keyATM).

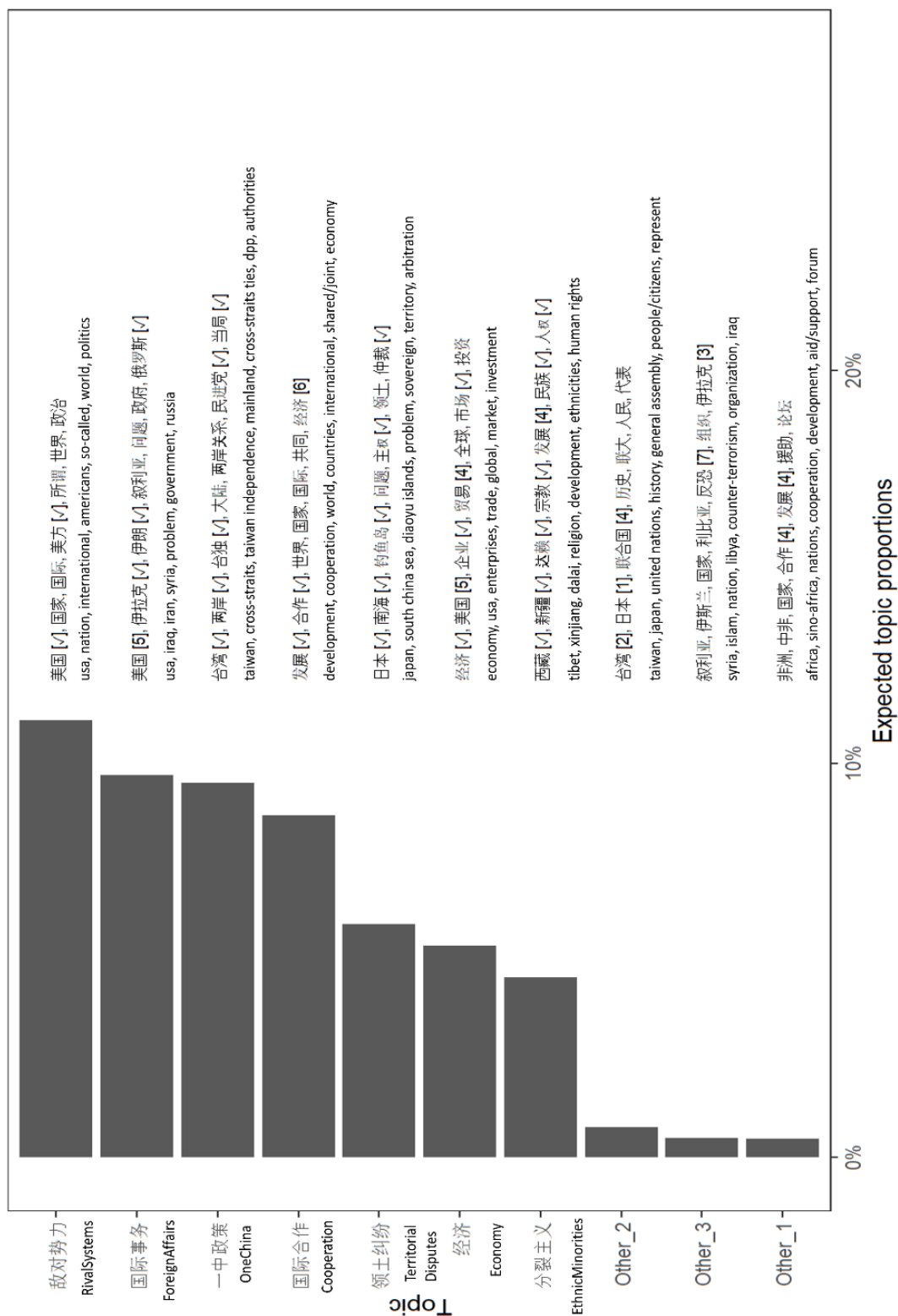


Figure 6. Distribution of top 10 topics and corresponding keywords across Chinese-language articles (keyATM).

Evaluating Variation Over Time

Next, we examine the temporal trends of each topic using the dynamic keyATM function. *Figures 7 and 8* display those results. We observe that the topic proportions change in response to real-world events and the news cycle, and this allows us to validate the performance of the keyATM model. For example, the spikes in the topic prevalence of territorial disputes reflect the 2012 Senkaku/Diaoyu islands dispute between China and Japan, and the Permanent Court of Arbitration’s ruling in favour of the Philippines in the South China Sea dispute in 2016. The spike in the topic prevalence of ethnic minorities in 2008 is likely to reflect the 2008 Tibetan uprising and repression and the global attention it garnered in the lead-up to the Beijing Olympics. The intensification of the US-China trade war that was initiated by the Trump administration is likely to be captured by the spike in the topic prevalence of the economy in 2018.

While most of the topics experience plenty of variation in terms of prevalence over time, the ‘Rival Systems’ topic is the only one which appears to show a clear continuous upward trend over time in both samples, indicating an underlying strategy to bolster the Chinese model and undermine the United States. We further validated the performance of the keyATM model with manual inspection of the top documents per topic, finding that 76.2% and 85.7% of the English and Chinese samples fit well to their assigned topics.

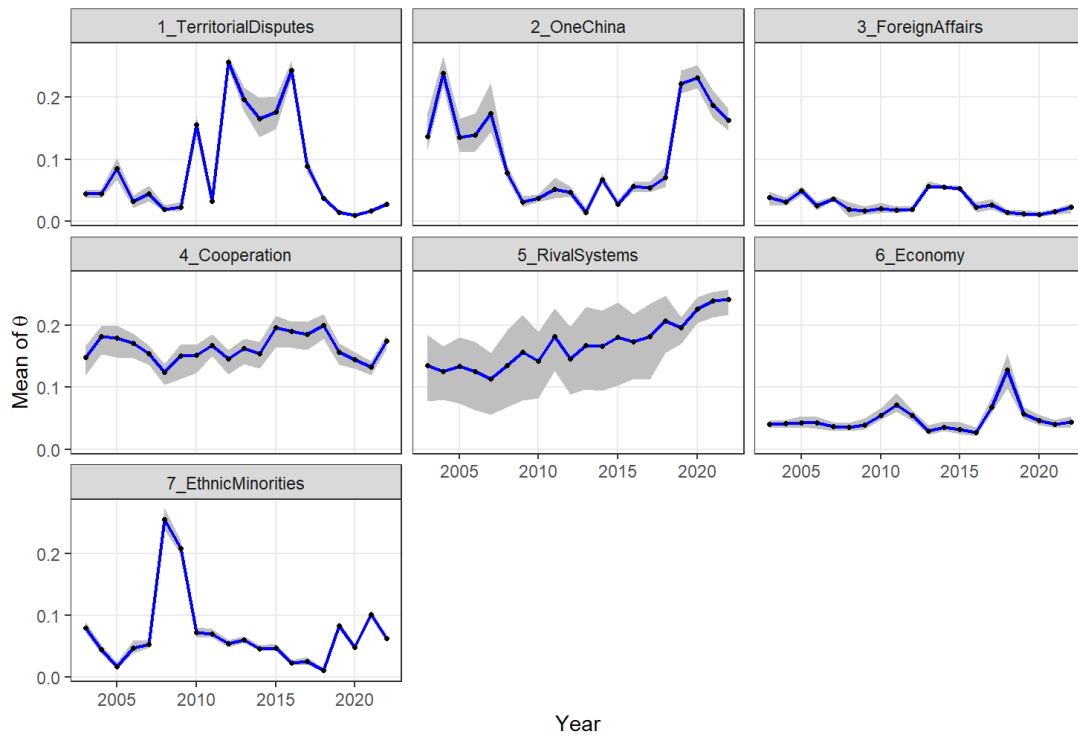


Figure 7. Topic prevalence over time in the English-language corpus (keyATM).

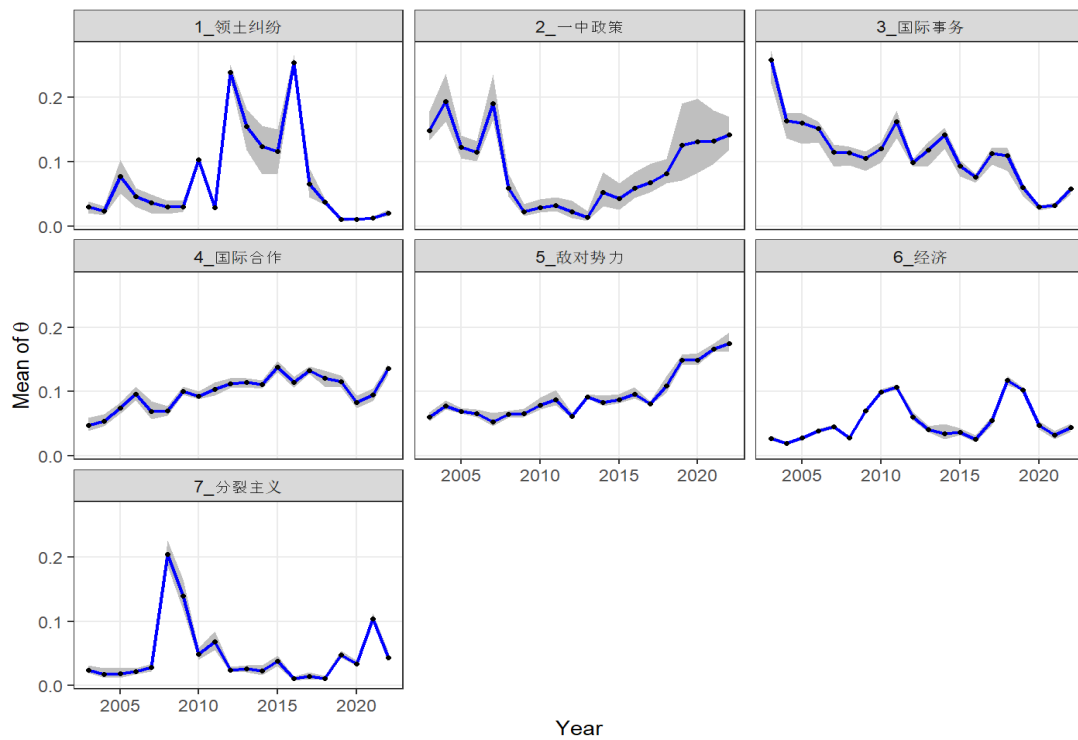


Figure 8. Topic prevalence over time in the Chinese-language corpus (keyATM). The order of the plots corresponds to the order in Figure 7.

Exploring Ideas Targeted for Discrediting

Overall, we find that sarcastic uses of *so-called* tend to precede ideas, claims, or criticism that the Chinese state finds objectionable. In some cases *so-called* is used to convey that the intended meaning is the opposite of the literal meaning in the text, for example, *so-called* respect for human rights and freedom in the US, or *so-called* genocide in Xinjiang. In other cases, *so-called* is used to signal that the concept/entity in question is not recognised or is not legitimate in the eyes of the Chinese state, for example, the Taiwan referendum, or Hong Kong democratic primaries.

To better understand the specific ideas that are being discredited with the *so-called* rhetorical device, we extracted the top ten documents for ‘Territorial Disputes’ and ‘Ethnic Minorities’, topics with similar temporal trends across both English and Chinese corpora.¹⁰

Within the sample of documents that are highly associated with the ‘Territorial Disputes’ topic, 88% of the time *so-called* was used to discredit Japanese and Filipino maritime territorial claims and their corresponding actions. For example, *so-called* was used to call into question Japan’s “nationalization” of the islands, which involved its “purchase” from private Japanese citizens in 2012. The device was also used to undermine the interpretation of the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, which forms the basis of the Filippino arbitration case against China. In a small number of cases in the English corpus, *so-called* was directed at US actions deemed illegitimate, such as “transferr[ing] the so-called ‘administrative authority’ [of the Diaoyu islands] to Japan in the 1970s”, and the staging of “so-called ‘freedom of navigation operations’ close to Chinese waters, ahead of a July 12 ruling by the Permanent Court of Arbitration (PCA) in The Hague”.

Within the sample of documents that are highly associated with the ‘Ethnic Minorities’ topic, 75% of the time, *so-called* was used to discredit the idea that China

represses its Uyghur minority in Xinjiang, including research that has found evidence of forced labour, forced sterilizations, and cultural genocide. In the remaining instances, *so-called* was directed at US actions directed at China, including the Uyghur Human Rights Policy Act, the Hong Kong Autonomy Act, and a “conference on so-called promoting religious freedom”, which refers to the 2019 Ministerial To Advance Religious Freedom hosted by then Secretary of State Mike Pompeo.

In both samples, US actions that opposed China’s interest or supported its critics, such as freedom of navigation patrols or legislation relevant to Xinjiang or Hong Kong, were countered more prominently in English than in Chinese. While US actions perceived as hostile to China need to be countered by *Xinhua*’s English edition as part of the current regime’s push to win international discourse power, these actions appear to be less widely publicized in *Xinhua*’s Chinese edition. This is perhaps because they are tangible actions that can offer support to China’s critics. This suggests the existence of a domestic strategy to selectively reduce the issue salience of inconvenient or sensitive foreign affairs topics, thereby contributing to research on this information management strategy in autocracies (see Carter and Carter 2023, 185-190; Widmer 2024).

Detecting Country Mentions Using Word-Frequency Analysis

Finally, given the prevalence of the United States in these results we wanted to dig further to compare it with other countries whose ideas or actions are discredited with the *so-called* device. We conducted a word-frequency analysis using multi-language geographical dictionaries in Newsmap (Watanabe 2018). Excluding China, Hong Kong, and Taiwan, across both corpora, the US was by far the most frequently mentioned country, followed by Japan.¹¹ In the English dataset, the US was mentioned

11,233 times, accounting for 14% of all country mentions. In the Chinese dataset, the US accounted for a quarter of all country mentions. It had with 65,367 mentions, nearly four times that of second-placed Japan. It is worth noting that there are countries – Iraq, for example – that rank within the top ten, where the *so-called* device is often being used to criticize US foreign policy actions. These results lend further support to the conclusion that ideas and actions supported by or associated with the United States are target number 1 for the use of *so-called* as a propaganda device in China.

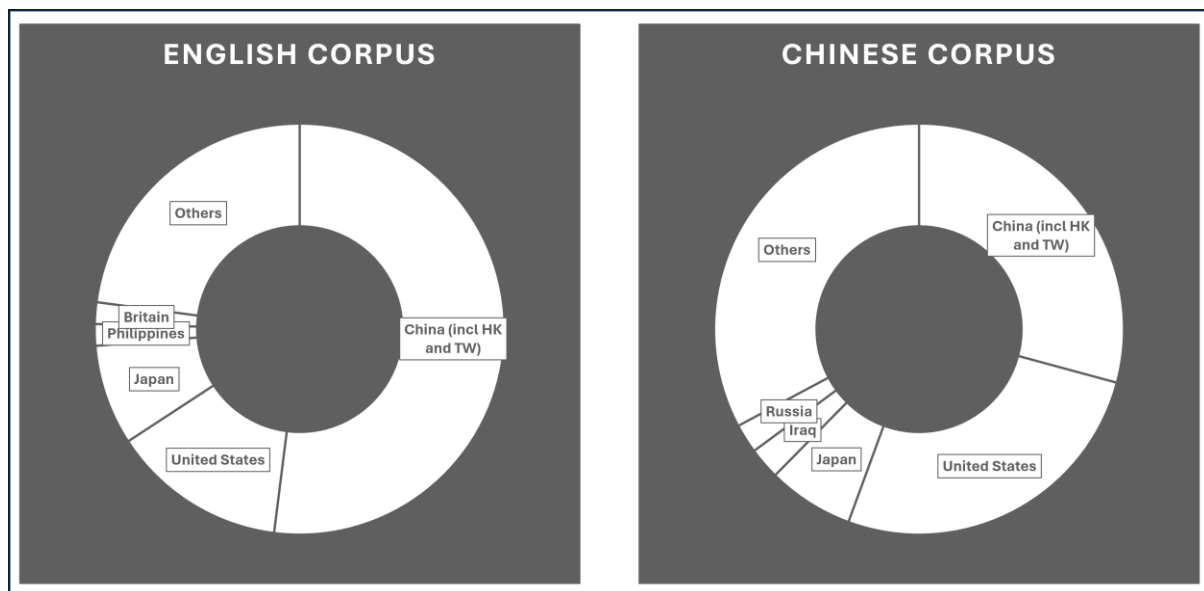


Figure 9. Top country mentions across both corpora.

Conclusion

This research note has investigated the dynamics of the linguistic marker *so-called*/所谓 (usually along with inverted commas) in PRC propaganda. In sum, *Xinhua* not only continues to use *so-called* as a propaganda device, but also its frequency has

increased since around 2018. It can be inferred that the propaganda apparatus sees a renewed need to de-legitimize words or actions it perceives as threatening to its interests. In addition to criticisms of its core interests, the United States emerges as a particular focus in *Xinhua*'s de-legitimizing rhetoric in both samples, but especially for its Chinese-language audience. This is consistent with Garver (2016: 812-814), who argues that the CCP leadership sees the US as leading an ideological campaign against it and that the party aims to inoculate its population in response. In both samples the focus on the US has dramatically increased in recent years, which is consistent with Xi Jinping's focus on combatting 'Western' influence since he came to power.¹²

Of course, given the space constraints of the research note format our study has many limitations in terms of timespan, source selection, and audience reception and is by no means the final word on this topic. Nevertheless, two brief conclusions can be drawn. First, this research note demonstrates the utility of focusing on the ideas that propagandists wish to discredit. Doing so allows a window into the political ideas that authorities find threatening to their power. Second, in the PRC context, clearly the United States is perceived as a threatening rival that the authorities wish to delegitimize. The proportion of articles that focus on discrediting the US out of all possible topics is remarkable and appears to be increasing with time, possibly in response to more hawkish US policy towards China in recent years. This suggests that the US-China rivalry will continue to be important not only for China's foreign relations but also its domestic politics as its population continues to be presented with material that discredits ideas associated with the US.

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¹ For ease of reading, we use *so-called* to refer to both the English usage and 所谓.

² Yurchak draws on a 1982 issue of the Soviet journal *Issues in Linguistics* for this insight.

³ For a recent review of authoritarian propaganda that addresses these debates, see Rosenfeld and Wallace 2024.

⁴ For the external audience, we focus only on *Xinhua*’s English content although Brazys and Dukalskis (2020) find differences between *Xinhua*’s editions across languages. It can be inferred that English content is mostly aimed at English-speaking countries and transnational audiences given English’s prevalence.

⁵ See figures in Section A.4 of the Appendix.

⁶ See details in Section C.1 of the Appendix.

⁷ See details in Section C.2 of the Appendix.

⁸ We note that *so-called* appears in the ‘Rival Systems’ category in Figures 5 & 6. This is because in this category, *so-called* tends to appear multiple times within each document, for e.g., “Any violent action under the guise of promoting *so-called* democracy or justice is in fact trampling on democratic theories and ideas, he added. Wang said while exporting its *so-called* democracy and touting its own brand of democracy, the United States should reflect on the limitations of its own democratic model.” [text17878]

⁹ See details in Section C.3 of the Appendix.

¹⁰ See details in Section D.1 of the Appendix.

¹¹ See details in Section D.2 of the Appendix.

¹² This began almost immediately. See reference to Document 9 above, and Buckley (2013). We interpret these developments as more than just signalling nationalist credentials to a nationalistic audience and reflective of a deeper desire to persuade readers that the Chinese model is superior to the US one.